

Main Idea - Practice Workbook

Twelve focused questions. Every item practices the same core skill: identify the idea that best fits the text as a whole.

How to use this workbook

For each passage, first write your own one-sentence main idea. Then answer both questions. Do not check the answer key until you finish the set.

Passage 1 - Night Lights and Insects

Many cities are replacing older streetlights with energy-efficient LEDs. The change can lower electricity use, but researchers have also studied how nighttime lighting affects insects. Some insects navigate partly by natural light from the moon and stars. Bright artificial light can pull them away from feeding or breeding areas and keep them circling lamps for long periods. Newer streetlights can be designed to point downward, and some cities use warmer-colored bulbs that attract fewer insects. These choices do not remove every effect of night lighting, but they can reduce unnecessary light while still keeping streets visible for people.

1. Which statement best expresses the central idea of Passage 1?

- A. LED streetlights always harm insects more than older streetlights.
- B. Cities can reduce some effects of artificial night lighting by considering how streetlights are designed and used.
- C. Insects use only moonlight to navigate at night.
- D. Streetlights should be removed from all areas where insects live.

2. Which title best reflects the main idea of Passage 1?

- A. Why Insects Fly Around Lamps
- B. Making Night Lighting More Thoughtful
- C. The History of LED Streetlights
- D. Why Cities Need Brighter Roads

Passage 2 - A Better Shift Handoff

At a small manufacturing plant, workers on the morning and evening shifts used to exchange information by speaking for a few minutes near the time clock. Important details were sometimes forgotten, especially when the plant was busy. The company introduced a short handoff checklist that asks the outgoing team to record machine problems, unfinished orders, safety concerns, and materials that need restocking. Supervisors still encourage workers to speak directly when a problem is urgent. After several weeks, teams reported fewer repeated checks and fewer surprises at the start of a shift. The checklist did not replace conversation; it gave each conversation a more reliable starting point.

3. Which statement best expresses the central idea of Passage 2?

- A. The checklist improved shift communication by making important information less likely to be missed.
- B. Workers should stop talking during shift changes.
- C. Manufacturing plants have too many unfinished orders.
- D. Supervisors should complete every checklist themselves.

4. Which statement is too narrow to serve as the main idea of Passage 2?

- A. A short checklist gave workers a more reliable way to begin shift handoffs.

- B. The plant wanted important shift information to be passed on more consistently.
- C. The checklist includes a place to record materials that need restocking.
- D. Written notes and direct conversation can work together during a shift change.

Passage 3 - Rain Gardens

During heavy rain, water can rush across roofs, roads, and parking lots instead of soaking into the ground. Some neighborhoods are using rain gardens to slow that runoff. A rain garden is a shallow planted area that temporarily collects water and allows more of it to soak into the soil. The plants can also trap some sediment before the water reaches storm drains. Rain gardens are not suitable for every location, and they do not prevent flooding by themselves. However, when they are placed carefully and combined with other drainage measures, they can help manage stormwater while adding vegetation to developed areas.

5. Which statement best expresses an idea developed throughout Passage 3?

- A. Rain gardens can be one useful part of a broader stormwater strategy.
- B. Rain gardens prevent all neighborhood flooding.
- C. Parking lots should be replaced with gardens.
- D. Rain gardens work best without any other drainage measures.

6. Which statement is too broad to be the main idea of Passage 3?

- A. Rain gardens collect runoff and help some water soak into soil.
- B. Rain gardens can help manage stormwater when used in suitable places with other measures.
- C. Plants are the solution to every problem caused by urban development.

D. Rain gardens can add vegetation while serving a drainage purpose.

Passage 4 - Library Late Fees

The Northside Library stopped charging daily late fees on most books and magazines. Library leaders said small fines often discouraged people from returning after an item became overdue, especially when a family had several items checked out. Borrowers are still responsible for returning materials, and accounts are temporarily blocked when an item is long overdue. A replacement charge may apply if the material is never returned. During the first year of the policy, more overdue items came back and hundreds of inactive borrowers began using their cards again. The library kept due dates but changed how it responded when people missed them.

7. Which statement best expresses the central idea of Passage 4?

- A. The library removed due dates from books and magazines.
- B. Replacing daily late fees with other return rules encouraged more borrowers and overdue materials to come back.
- C. Every overdue library item is now free to keep.
- D. Late fees are the main source of income for public libraries.

8. Which title best reflects the main idea of Passage 4?

- A. Keeping Due Dates, Changing the Penalty
- B. The Most Popular Books at Northside Library
- C. How to Pay a Replacement Charge
- D. Why Libraries Should Never Have Rules

Passage 5 - The Green Notebook

Mira found the green notebook while clearing a shelf in her grandfather's workshop. Most pages were filled with measurements, sketches, and lists of materials, but several pages showed unfinished designs for a folding table. Her grandfather had stopped woodworking after an injury years earlier. Mira studied the drawings for several evenings, then asked if she could try building the table. He warned her that the measurements might need changing and offered advice only when she asked. When the finished table finally stood level on the workshop floor, he ran a hand across its edge and smiled. Mira wrote the final measurements in the notebook before returning it to the shelf.

9. Which statement best expresses an idea developed throughout Passage 5?

- A. Mira proves that old measurements are always correct.
- B. Her grandfather wants Mira to become a professional woodworker.
- C. Working from her grandfather's unfinished design allows Mira to continue something meaningful while making it her own.
- D. The folding table is the most valuable object in the workshop.

10. Which statement is too narrow to serve as the main idea of Passage 5?

- A. Mira uses an unfinished family project as a chance to learn and continue her grandfather's work.
- B. Mira records the final measurements in the green notebook.
- C. The story shows knowledge being passed from one generation to another.
- D. Mira completes a project that connects her effort with her grandfather's earlier work.

Passage 6 - Seed Banks

Farmers around the world grow thousands of plant varieties, but some varieties disappear when farming practices, climate, or markets change. Seed banks preserve samples so that useful genetic traits are not lost completely. Seeds are dried and stored under controlled conditions, and staff periodically test whether they can still germinate. Collections can help researchers study traits such as drought tolerance or disease resistance. A seed bank cannot protect crops growing in fields, and stored seeds still require careful maintenance. Its value is in keeping biological options available for future research and breeding.

11. Which statement best expresses the central idea of Passage 6?

- A. Seed banks preserve plant diversity so useful genetic traits remain available for future study and breeding.
- B. Seed banks can protect every crop from drought and disease.
- C. Researchers store seeds mainly because farmers no longer grow food.
- D. Seeds remain alive forever once they are placed in cold storage.

12. Which statement is too narrow to serve as the main idea of Passage 6?

- A. Seed banks keep biological options available even when some crop varieties disappear from fields.
- B. Stored seeds must be tested to see whether they can still germinate.
- C. Seed banks preserve genetic material that may be useful in future research.
- D. Seed storage requires maintenance but can protect valuable diversity for later use.

Check your reasoning, not just the letter

1. B - It covers both the benefit of efficient lighting and the passage's main concern: reducing unnecessary effects on insects through better design.
2. B - The passage is not mainly about LEDs or insect behavior alone; it is about using lighting more thoughtfully.
3. A - Every major detail points to the checklist making handoffs more dependable without replacing direct conversation.
4. C - Restocking is only one item on the checklist, so it cannot represent the whole passage.
5. A - The author presents rain gardens as useful but limited, and specifically says they work with other drainage measures.
6. C - The passage discusses one stormwater tool. It does not support a claim about every urban problem.
7. B - The main change is not the removal of responsibility; it is a different late-return policy that encouraged returns and renewed use.
8. A - The library kept due dates while changing the financial penalty, which captures the central contrast.
9. C - The notebook, unfinished design, grandfather's advice, and Mira's final notes all develop the idea of continuing and adapting meaningful work.
10. B - Writing the final measurements is one closing detail, not the story's larger point.

11. A - The passage explains why seed banks preserve varieties and how that preserved diversity can support future research and breeding.

12. B - Germination testing is important, but it is one maintenance detail rather than the main point.

Main-idea reminder

The correct central idea usually needs support from several parts of the text. If an answer fits only one sentence or paragraph, it is probably too narrow.